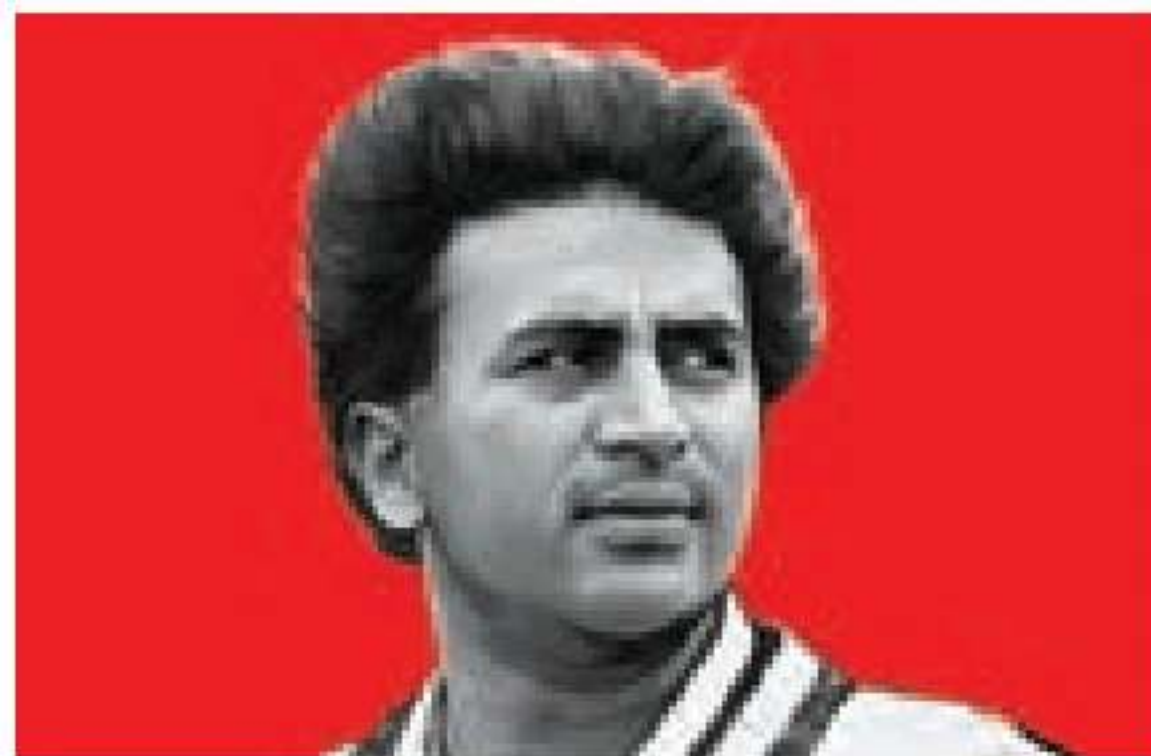




ON THE WRITE LINE

Sunil Gavaskar



FOR MORE
STORIES

CREDIT TO AJIT AGARKAR AND FELLOW SELECTORS FOR PITCHFORKING NITISH REDDY INTO TEST CRICKET

The Melbourne Test brought to the fore one of the **brightest young stars** in Indian cricket, Nitish Kumar Reddy.

Why Test cricket is the ultimate format of the game was seen at the magnificent Melbourne Cricket Ground. It was a match between two hugely talented and competitive teams, which brought a fitting end to what has truly been a memorable year for the sport, but more so for Indian cricket.

India won a World Cup after 11 years when they won the ICC T20 World Cup that was played in the West Indies with some games in the USA. That made up to some extent for the disappointment of losing in the final of the 50-over ODI World Cup at home in Ahmedabad in 2023.

There was more disappointment coming India's way as New Zealand did the unthinkable and beat them in all three Test matches at home to dent India's chances of qualifying for the final of the World Test Championship.

Then, it was off to Australia, where India had had successes on the last two tours. They began with a great win in Perth but then lost badly in Adelaide and showed great determination in the washed-out Gabba Test match. By the time the Melbourne Test came

along, the Aussie media recognised that this team was not a pushover as some of the other countries that had toured Australia in recent times had been, and so, as is their wont, they began to find some incident or other to try and get under India's skin. Indian players since the mid-70s have known that the Aussie media is almost like an extension of their support staff, so they simply don't take them seriously, whatever they may have to say or write. Trying to get eyeballs is an old trick that has become even more intense with the advent of internet media, and peddling lies is an everyday thing.

The Melbourne Test brought to the fore one of the brightest young stars in Indian cricket, Nitish Kumar Reddy. He came to the attention of the Indian cricket fans with his performances for the Hyderabad franchise in the IPL, and while he had not done much at the first-class level, it's a credit to Ajit Agarkar and his fellow selectors to have seen enough to pitchfork him into the Test arena. In his debut Test match in Perth itself, it became evident that here was a cricketer who could read situations and play accordingly. With every subsequent Test match, that impression of a good 'cricketing head' on his shoulders began